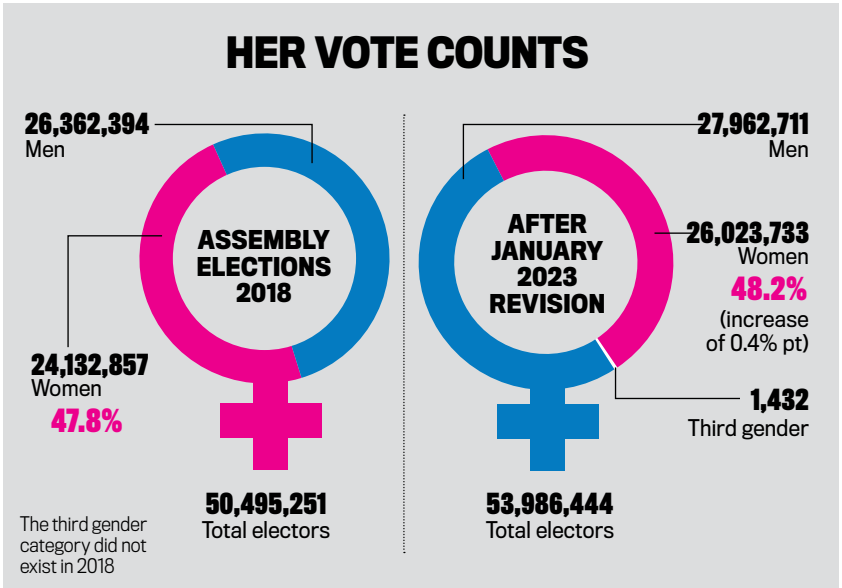
domiciled in MP. When announced initially at the end of January, the CM had included all women above 23 who did not belong to an income tax-paying family, sparking off concerns about the scheme's financial burden. In the days that followed, the bureaucracy prevailed on Chouhan and introduced a number of filters that have narrowed the beneficiary base. Among these are the ownership of a four-wheeler, including a tractor, by the claimant's family, employment of a family member in the government and ownership of more than five acres of agricultural land.



Registrations for the LBY began on March 5, Chouhan's 64th birthday, and had touched 4.8 million by April 3. Nearly 10 million women are estimated to be included in the scheme in the first year, entailing an outflow of Rs 10,000 crore annually. The current budget provides for Rs 8,000 crore for the LBY, with supplementary demands expected to meet the remaining amount. Payments under the scheme are to commence from June. "The Ladli Behana Yojana has become a public campaign," Chouhan said while addressing his cabinet colleagues on April 4. "Even at places where servers are down and online registrations halted briefly, people were sitting outside and manually filling up forms. There is genuine enthusiasm for the scheme."

The LBY has its genesis in a scheme at work in the tribal welfare department. Concerned over the falling health indices of Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups (PVTG), which include the Bharias, Baigas and Sahariyas in MP, the state government had in 2018 started an Aahaar Anudaan scheme under which monthly support of Rs 1,000 was extended to the female head of the PVTG family. A review of the scheme by the Bengaluru-based Dr Ambedkar School of Economics University found that the payout had resulted in dramatic improvement in the health indices of the entire family as most of the money made available was spent on nutrition. Chouhan and his party, however, are looking only at the political mileage they can extract from the scheme rather than its advantages as a targeted scheme.

Even with the focus on the scheme's political potential, how do the numbers stack up for Chouhan? The population of women in MP in 2023 is estimated to be 40.1 million, and women voters comprise 48.2 per cent of its 53.9 million-strong electorate. After the revision of the electoral rolls this year, 1.34 million voters were added, of which more than 700,000 were women. Among the new voters, the number of female voters increased by 2.8 per cent while male voters by 2.3 per cent. In 2018, the vote percentage among women was 73.9, and 75.7 among men. With women having a greater share among the new voters, they are also expected to vote in greater numbers in 2023. Women voters outnumber men in 18 of the 230 seats in the assembly. Interestingly, these are all tribal-dominated seats. Tribals are another demographic the BJP has been trying to woo.

WHILE ANNOUNCING NEW SCHEMES TARGETED AT WOMEN, CHOUHAN IS ALSO REPURPOSING EXISTING SCHEMES TO BENEFIT WOMEN

Besides the LBY, which has top-of-the-mind recall with voters as per numerous surveys, Chouhan is also rebooting existing schemes to benefit women. In November 2022, he announced Ladli Laxmi Yojana 2.0, in which a provision for Rs 25,000 was introduced for higher education. To finance the same, Rs 929 crore has been provided as budgetary support. The budget has also allocated Rs 660 crore to subsidise loans to all women's self-help groups (SHGs). The SHGs have, of late, also emerged as a political tool. Its members are carted to every political rally that is disguised as a government programme, where they are made aware of the benefits accruing to them through the low-interest loans, in the hope that this awareness will eventually translate into votes for the ruling party. The massive reach that SHGs have can be gauged from

